

The Multiplicity of Meaning, chapters 3 and 4

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1 Chapter 3: defending the classical approach to the Sorites

Here are some handy definitions, where being F is any property of natural numbers:

- Being F is **tolerant** iff every F number has an F successor.¹
- Being F is **bounded** iff some F number does not have an F successor.
- Being F is **universal** iff every number is F .

¹ The **successor** of a natural number is the result of adding 1 to it.

Let N be some largish number, say 100.

INDUCTION Every tolerant property had by zero is had by N (premise).

CONTRAPOSED INDUCTION So, every property had by zero but not N is not tolerant (from INDUCTION).

INTOLERANCE Every property that is not tolerant is bounded (premise).

BOUNDEDNESS So, every property had by zero but not N is bounded (from CONTRAPOSED INDUCTION and INTOLERANCE).

Many philosophers find BOUNDEDNESS repugnant: they think that, e.g., being much smaller than 100 is a property of 0 that is not universal, but they find it absurd to suppose that it is bounded.²

I think BOUNDEDNESS is true, so we should look for a way of overcoming the sense of repugnance that it inspires.

² I think that arguments for Boundedness—or for particular claims of boundedness that could be inferred from it and obvious truths—have a much better claim on the title “paradox” than standard presentations of Sorites paradoxes that turn on a ‘Tolerance’ premise to the effect that some property (e.g. being much smaller than 100) is tolerant.

2 Ways of resisting

- Rejecting the last step (from INTOLERANCE to BOUNDEDNESS) would require giving up on:

BARBARA Every F thing is G .
 Every G thing is H .
 —————
 Every F thing is H .

- Rejecting INTOLERANCE (as intuitionists do) requires giving up on:

NOT EVERY Not every F thing is G
 —————
 Some F thing is not G

- Rejecting the step from INDUCTION to CONTRAPOSED INDUCTION requires giving up on

$$\text{CONTRAPOSITION+} \quad \frac{\text{Every } F \text{ thing that is } G \text{ is } H.}{\text{Every } F \text{ thing that is not } H \text{ is not } G.}$$

- Rejecting INDUCTION requires giving up on

$$\text{GENERALIZED INSTANTIATION} \quad \frac{\begin{array}{l} \text{Every } F \text{ Ss everything it Rs.} \\ \text{Every } F \text{ Rs } a. \end{array}}{\text{Every } F \text{ Ss } a.}$$

These logically revisionary options all seem to me decisively *more* repugnant and absurd than that of accepting BOUNDEDNESS!

3 *Setting aside a bad argument for pluralism*

One might be tempted to argue for pluralism from the premise that whenever y and y' are extremely similar (both in themselves and in their relations to x), then unless x has extraordinary powers of discrimination, x cannot bear some intentional relation to y but not to y' . So, if x bears such a relation to an object that is extremely similar to many others, it will bear it to all of those many others.

This thought leads to Soritical disaster and must be given up!

A thought that does *not* need to be given up is that when x bears R to y and y' is extremely similar to many other things, x bears R to *many* (but maybe not all!) of those other things.

But one would need some special reason to accept this for intentional relations, since *prima facie* it fails for many other familiar relations. E.g. *being advised by*; *being a child of*; *being two things the first of which is Kit Fine and the second of which is Hartry Field*.

The “problem of the many” (Unger 1980) is based on the idea that it is somehow absurd to only one member of some collection of very similar, near-coincident objects is a person/cat/cloud/... But there is nothing *more* absurd about this than there is in the idea that a bald and a non-bald person could differ by a hair.

4 *“Explaining away” our aversion to Boundedness*

The diagnostic project: explain why we are so resistant to instances of Boundedness, given that they are true. Hope: a good explanation of this will diminish our resistance.

Proposal: the resistance rests implicitly on (false) assumptions of monism for some familiar intentional relations, in a way that can be made explicit by the following argument.

UNSHARPNESS No number with every property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’ is such that its successor has *no* property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’.

MEANING ‘Much smaller than 100’ expresses *being much smaller than 100*.

UNIQUENESS ‘Much smaller than 100’ expresses at most one property.

UNBOUNDEDNESS No number that is much smaller than 100 is such that its successor is not much smaller than 100.

We (implicitly) know UNSHARPNESS because we are sensitive to the “vagueness-conducive” way in which ‘much smaller than 100’ is used, from which it follows.

- Of course, the idea can’t be that we are implicitly aware to the same extent of *every* truth about the meaning-theoretic upshots of these use facts. For example, the use facts in fact secure that ‘much smaller than 100’ expresses multiple properties, but we are not gripped by an inclination to think that it both does and does not express multiple properties.³

On this picture, although the Sorites is not *about* language, its standard classification as part of the philosophy of language is correct since its grip rests implicitly on thoughts about language. Many explanations of the paradox bring this linguistic element to surface.

Worry: The sentence (UNSHARPNESS) doesn’t *sound* very natural or gripping. *Reply:* that’s because its verbal formulation gives rise, via an ‘anti-presupposition’ effect, to the inference that UNIQUENESS is false.

Worry: there is no more basis for attributing our resistance to UNSHARPNESS than to any of the following, which can be substituted without disrupting the validity of the argument, and sound just as good:

UNSHARPNESS^{∀∀} No number with every property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’ is such that its successor does not have every property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’.

UNSHARPNESS^{∃∃} No number with some property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’ is such that its successor has no property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’.

UNSHARPNESS^{∃∀} No number with some property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’ is such that its successor has every property expressed by ‘much smaller than 100’.

Reply: these are all *false*, so their appeal just pushes back the need for explanation. We’re looking for an explanation that taps into some (partial) sensitivity to the *truth*.

Challenge: Why do we slip into assuming UNIQUENESS, given that it’s false? *Response:* some combination of (a) simple wrong turns taken in the history of philosophy; (b) sliding between the count

³ Thus, our sensitivity to the truth of UNSHARPNESS does not predict that when *x* has a middling number of hairs and *y* has a middling number of dollars, it will strike us as obviously false that *x* has every property expressed by ‘bald’ and *y* has no property expressed by ‘rich’.

noun and mass noun uses of words like ‘meaning’; (c) lack of sensitivity to the fact that ordinary ‘I only said one thing’ speeches involve restricted quantifier domains.

5 *Comparison with other explanations*

What about a structurally parallel explanation substituting a term of art like ‘is an admissible interpretation of’ for ‘is expressed by’?⁴

Problem: (a) appeal to such theoretical posits isn’t plausible as an explanation of a temptation that even neophytes feel; (b) attributing to neophytes an implicit assumption of UNIQUENESS for the theoretical posit is extra-implausible, given that the failure of UNIQUENESS in cases of vagueness is central to its ‘theoretical role’.

A similar issue arises for explanations that invoke some non-metalinguistic, non-epistemic ‘definitely’ operator. It’s central to the theoretical role of the operator that it’s non-redundant in this sort of context, so if people are implicitly treating some operator as redundant, it seems perverse to interpret them as thinking about *this* operator.

Williamson (1994: 507) says we find [instances of] UNBOUNDEDNESS appealing because, in general, ‘we are tempted to deny the truth of a proposition when we cannot conceive (even in broad outline) a way of coming to know its truth’. I think this may be a good explanation for some philosophers in the verificationist/Dummettian tradition, but the attribution of such quasi-verificationist thoughts to the “folk” seems a stretch.⁵

6 *Explaining the speech behavior associated with vagueness*

There’s another puzzle associated with vagueness, that’s only tangentially related to the Sorites. In a range of cases (‘borderline cases’), even well-informed speakers are averse to giving flat ‘yes’ and ‘no’ answers to a yes-no question. They prefer to *hedge*, often by offering more detail.⁶ *Question:* Why do we prefer to avoid just saying ‘yes’ or ‘no’ in such cases?

Basic pluralist answer: If we said ‘yes’ or ‘no’ (without lots of clarification), we would be asserting something something false, and we don’t want to do that.

Bonus: Pluralism also neatly explains another fact that some other accounts struggle with, namely that we are *also* averse to just saying ‘I don’t know’ in these cases (without further clarification). *Explanation:* saying ‘I don’t know’ would also involve asserting something false, since some of the propositions we were asked about are ones we *do* know (or know to be false).

Of course there are lots of other possible explanations of these familiar facts; trying to catalogue and compare them would take us too far afield. Instead I think it’s better to focus on an explanan-

⁴ Or: ‘is a partial referent of’, ‘is expressed on some precisification by’, ...

⁵ Also, there are many subject matters where we feel no Sorites-like puzzlement for which knowledge is possible, if it all, only for creatures with abilities vastly greater than ours. It’s very far from obvious that they are possible, so it’s not plausible that our lack of puzzlement arises from some sort of assumption that it is possible.

⁶ Are most philosophy professors writers? — Well, most of them write papers and books aimed at other philosophers, but only a few write for a general audience.
Is your brother bald? — He does have a pretty big bald spot.
Are you in a relationship? — It’s complicated.

dum that's harder for non-pluralists: the fact that even when speakers are constrained in such a way that saying 'yes' and saying 'no' (without followup) are the only options, different speakers break different ways, even when they are very well-informed and co-operative (motivated just by a desire to inform rather than mislead). Call this **forced-choice variability**.⁷

Forced-choice variability isn't mysterious for the pluralist. Compatibly with being "co-operative", different speakers can have different fine-grained preferences as between the deleterious consequences of saying 'no' and those of saying 'yes', even if there are no relevant differences in their beliefs.

But it's mysterious if there only one proposition *p* expressed by the question. If they all know it's the one expressed, shouldn't the policy *say 'yes' if p and 'no' if not-p* be a natural "co-ordination equilibrium", so if the speakers are all relevantly well-informed, they would all follow it and thus all say the same thing?

"Epistemicist" response: There is a single proposition expressed (asserted, meant...), but no ordinary speakers, even well-informed ones, can know whether it's true.

– This seems deeply implausible!

(i) In simple signalling systems (fruit exploration case), analogues of forced-choice variability can readily arise without relevant uncertainty; and the differences seem just a matter of degree.

(ii) In realistic cases of forced-choice variability, the differences between different co-operative speakers' reactions are driven by differences of preference, not of credence—'Have all the cups been washed?'

(iii) Epistemicism can't explain why it's often bad to answer 'no' to 'Do you know whether *P*?'

(iv) The epistemicist explanation conflicts with the only workable monist response to Argument One (see last week's handout). That response involves making the following speech when one is in a specialized context: 'The property of being a cup is the one that ordinary indifferent uses of 'cup' express; it's a property that glasses instantiate [/do not instantiate], and we are in a position to know that.'

Non-epistemicist, non-pluralist response: Although there is only one proposition expressed, *expressing* plays no special role in our preference systems. Speakers don't *care* any more about avoiding sentences that *express* falsehoods than about avoiding sentences that bear any of many other one-one relations to falsehoods. So there is nothing to make 'express a truth' a co-ordination equilibrium.

– This is workable, so the argument isn't a full success. However, it concedes pluralism in the case of relations like *caring about*.

⁷ It's the basis of the argument in Williamson 1994: 199 that 'we have no idea how to conceive borderline cases in such a way that nothing in them lies hidden from ordinary speakers'.

References

- Unger, Peter (1980), 'The Problem of the Many', *Midwest Studies in Philosophy*, 5/1: 411–68.
- Williamson, Timothy (1994), *Vagueness* (London: Routledge).